

eral secretary of the organisation. As a five-time Lok Sabha MP, former Union minister and three-time chief minister of Rajasthan, he also comes with vast legislative and administrative experience. He has been a minister in the Indira Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi and P.V. Narasimha Rao governments, and enjoyed the trust of three generations of Gandhis—Indira, then Sanjay, Rajiv and Sonia, and now Rahul and Priyanka.

He is also a prominent leader in the north, where the party has performed abysmally in the previous two Lok Sabha polls. Adept in the art of realpolitik, he was also instrumental in the party's superlative performance in the assembly polls in Gujarat, Modi's home state, in 2017, and has been made the party's election observer for the Gujarat polls this year too.

Hailing from the Mali community, Gehlot is also an OBC (other backward class) leader, just like Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Almost all parties have been wooing the OBC votebank, who can be a swing factor in any election. He also shares a warm equation with most Opposition leaders, which can come in useful at a time the Congress is trying to build an alliance of Opposition parties to take on the BJP in the 2024 general election. With Sonia taking a back seat, and several Opposition leaders uncomfortable with Rahul's style of functioning, Gehlot could have acted as a bridge between different political formations. The Rajasthan chief minister is also known for his contacts among corporates whom he can rely on to generate funds to tide over the party's resource crunch.

He also has a good record in governance, with several of his government's schemes attracting positive feedback. He has also been able to successfully save his government, most notably from Pilot, unlike other chief ministers who have fallen prey to the BJP's machinations.

THE UNRAVELLING

But while the party saw considerable merit in Gehlot's candidature, he himself was reluctant to accept the organisational elevation and let go of the chief ministerial chair till he was left with no choice. He announced he would remain Rajasthan chief minister even if he is elected Congress president. He then got the party unit in Rajasthan to pass a resolution demanding Rahul Gandhi return as Congress president. This triggered a spate of such resolutions from other state Congress units. But Rahul remained adamant on his stand to not contest.

Meanwhile, speculation was rife that Pilot would replace him. On September 20, when Gehlot hosted vice president Jagdeep Dhankhar in Jaipur, many saw it as his farewell dinner. Later that night, at a CLP meeting, Gehlot told his MLAs that he would remain CM til at least the budget is presented in the assembly. When his detractors reminded him of the "one-man, one-post" principle adopted at the Udaipur Chintan Shivir in May, Gehlot said it applied to nominated, not elected positions. Never mind that Pilot himself was deputy CM and PCC president before his ill-advised coup stripped him of both positions. And, as a former chief minister said, "Till the result of the election on October 19, he will be holding only one post. So where is the question of him holding two posts?"

GEHLOT WAS NOT WILLING TO CEDE THE CM'S CHAIR TO PILOT, AND THE HIGH COMMAND WANTED HIM TO QUIT AS THEY FEARED HE'D HAVE A SAY ON HIS SUCCESSOR IF HE BECAME PRESIDENT

Another group of senior leaders—neutral to events in Rajasthan—had pointed out that Gehlot's resignation before the election would go against the Gandhis' stated stand of neutrality. "It's already assumed that he would win the contest because he is the chosen candidate of the Family, even though they may not declare it officially. How can they claim neutrality? The entire electoral exercise would become a farce then," says a Congress departmental head who did not want to be named. As it happened, that possibility will not come to pass.

Maken, however, claimed that the resignation was necessary to avoid conflict of interest. Had Gehlot become Congress president, he would have a say in the selection of his successor. Gehlot supporters dismissed the argument outright. Is there no conflict of interest in a PCC chief or AICC president deciding on his own ticket for elections? How could there be conflict then in Gehlot, as Congress president, having a say in the selection of Rajasthan CM, they argued.

Gehlot's hopes, however, were dashed on September 22, when Rahul Gandhi in a press conference in Kerala publicly reiterated the "one-man, one-post" doctrine. The statement came hours before Gehlot met Rahul in Kochi to make a final attempt to convince him to become the Congress president again. While Gehlot had by now reconciled to the idea of joining the presidential race, the public admonition by Rahul left him hurt. The Congress scion apparently asked the chief minister not to waste time persuading him to contest and instead go and file his nomination. But that still was not what triggered Gehlot's "rebellion".

In his three meetings with Sonia Gandhi in the past two months, Gehlot was under the fond impression that he would have a say in his successor's selection if he became the Congress president. He was dead against Pilot grabbing his chair. Pilot did not have the numbers that he did. Sonia asked him to leave the decision to her, but never categorically indicated